COMP1110 Computing and data science in everyday life

2026/27 Semester 1

# Guidelines for Project Plan

Last updated: 2026-09-21

This document explains the requirements for the Project Plan. Read it together with the Group Project Guidelines.

## Purpose

The Project Plan is a short proposal **(4–6 pages)** that defines what your group will study and shows that the idea is clear and workable. A reader outside your group should be able to tell: what question or design goal you have; what motivates it (everyday life, a recent scientific or technical development); how computing or data science comes in; what related work already exists; why your focus is still worth studying (a research gap); and how the five members will share the work.

The Project Plan is not the Final Report. You do not need a full technical design yet. You **do need** to show that a nontrivial computing or data science contribution is possible within this course (see *Expected Depth by Project Type* in the Group Project Guidelines).

## Suggested structure

You may organise the Project Plan under these headings:

1. Title and team members
2. Problem statement and/or solution concept
3. Computing and/or data science connection
4. Literature / background review
5. Feasibility, limitations, and ethics
6. Timeline and team roles

What to write in each section is described below. There is no separate “creativity” section: creativity is judged from your problem statement and how well the literature shows that this focus is rarely studied.

## Content Guidelines

### Problem statement and/or solution concept

State one clear research question or solution concept, give enough context for a reader to see what you mean, and say what is in or out of scope. Context may be an everyday setting, a very recent scientific result, or a news story you want to investigate. Write so that a classmate who was not in your meetings can restate the question without guessing. As noted in the Group Project Guidelines, a topic is a question or situation, not a single tool (for example, "use ChatGPT") and not a broad area name (for example, "health" or "social media").

Creativity is assessed from this problem statement together with the literature review section. Aim for a question or design goal that existing work rarely studies, or that builds on something very recent (within about two months). Merely being new to your group, unusual-sounding, or far from computing does not make a topic creative. We will not comment on creativity **before** you submit the Project Plan. You will receive our feedback after you submit.

### Computing and/or data science connection

Name the computing or data science concepts you will use and explain how each helps answer your question. State your main project type (development-oriented, data analysis, algorithmic, simulation/modelling, or hybrid; see *Expected Depth by Project Type* in the Group Project Guidelines). Show that a real technical contribution is possible later in the project. For each method or tool you mention (for example Python, ChatGPT, or machine learning), state briefly what it will do and how that helps answer the question; listing tools alone is not enough.

### Literature / background review

Cover related work broadly (about **5–10** sources such as papers, reliable articles, existing systems or products, datasets, or earlier analyses). Give a short note on each source rather than a deep discussion of every one, and write a clear overview instead of a list of links. Choose material that supports the **creativity** claim and the **feasibility** discussion (for example, methods or data others used). If little work addresses your exact problem, include

similar problems, methods, or settings and explain how yours differs. This section is required; it is marked under the grading criterion ***Creativity of topic***, not as a separate criterion.

### Feasibility, limitations, and ethics

Say, **at a high level**, what data or information you need and whether you can obtain it, what methods you plan to use next, and any ethics issues that apply (for example privacy, consent, or working with people). Note practical limitations of your plan (for example data access, time, or skills) and what you will not claim. Detailed design belongs in the Final Report.

### Timeline and team roles

Give dated or week-based milestones for the remaining work, and name who is responsible for which main tasks. Milestones and the task breakdown may change as the project goes on; this section is a starting point, but it still has to be reasonable. Saying that everyone will contribute equally, without milestones or named roles, does not meet this requirement.

## Assessment

The Project Plan is assessed on a **group** basis, not individually. The weights below apply within the Project Plan mark and sum to 100%. If something required for a criterion is missing (for example, little or no literature support for creativity), that criterion is capped at a lower band; other criteria are still marked on their own evidence.

## Rubric – Project Plan (20% of project total)

| **Criterion** | **Weight** |
|---|---|
| Creativity of topic | 25% |
| Connection to computing and/or data science concepts | 25% |
| Clarity of problem / solution description | 25% |
| Feasibility, limitations, and ethics | 10% |
| Document formatting, consistency, and language | 10% |
| Timeline & team roles | 5% |

## Creativity of topic – 25%

Whether the **problem statement** identifies a focus that existing work rarely studies or leaves open, or that is based on something very recent (within about two months). Markers judge this from the question itself (markers may do a quick Internet search, for example) together with the **literature** section (including work on similar problems when nothing matches exactly). A more complex solution, or a topic far from computing, does not raise this mark by itself; the **research gap** is what matters most.

| | |
|---|---|
| **Excellent** | The question or design goal is a clear rarely studied or very recent focus; literature (or closely related work) makes the claim believable. |
| **Good** | The focus looks mostly creative; literature support is present but less sharp. |
| **Satisfactory** | The focus is weak as a gap (broad, common, or mostly "new to us" / unusual-sounding) with little sense it is under-studied or timely. |
| **Fair** | No usable creativity; the topic looks crowded, tutorial-like, or hard to tell apart from common existing work; little or no useful literature support. |

## Connection to computing and/or data science concepts – 25%

How well you **link** the topic to computing or data science, and whether a nontrivial technical core looks possible later.

| | |
|---|---|
| **Excellent** | Concepts are named and linked to the question; the main project type is stated; the plan clearly points to later technical depth of the right kind. |
| **Good** | A solid computing or data science link is present; type or depth is thinner or only partly spelled out. |
| **Satisfactory** | Some computing or data science words or tools appear, but the link to the question is thin, generic, or underdeveloped; later depth looks doubtful. |
| **Fair** | Little real computing or data science content; tools are named without explaining their role, or the writing is only social or ethical. |

### Clarity of problem / solution description – 25%

How **clearly** you state the question or situation, and what you plan to investigate or design.

| | |
|---|---|
| **Excellent** | The question or design goal is specific; enough context is given (everyday, scientific, or other); scope is clear; a reader outside the group can restate the question in one sentence without guessing. |
| **Good** | Question and context are clear; one of scope, context, or wording is slightly incomplete or vague. |
| **Satisfactory** | The topic can be understood, but the question is broad, tool-led, or partly unclear; scope is weak or missing. |
| **Fair** | It is hard to tell what is being asked; the description is confused, incomplete, or only a broad area name. |

### Feasibility, limitations, and ethics – 10%

Whether the plan shows that the remaining work is **realistic** for this course, and that limitations have been considered. Discuss ethics if they apply (for example privacy, consent, or working with people).

| | |
|---|---|
| **Excellent** | Data or information needs, methods, and main limitations are addressed at a useful level; ethics are covered where they apply; the plan looks workable for five first-year students. |
| **Good** | Most of data/methods and limitations are covered; ethics included where needed; one area is thinner or slightly optimistic. |
| **Satisfactory** | Some feasibility content appears, but important parts (access to data, methods, or limits) are missing or vague; ethics omitted where they clearly apply. |
| **Fair** | Little usable feasibility thinking; ethics ignored where they clearly apply; or the plan looks clearly unrealistic. |

### Document formatting, consistency, and language – 10%

How consistent and easy to read the document is, including the clarity of the writing. The language does not need to be perfect or native-like, but it should be clear academic writing that does not leave readers confused. Unnecessary visual design that does not help clarity is not required or rewarded.

| | |
|---|---|
| **Excellent** | Headings, spacing, fonts, and citation style are consistent; references are clear enough to find; wording is clear enough that the argument is easy to follow. |
| **Good** | Mostly tidy formatting; language is mostly clear, with only minor wording issues that do not block understanding. |
| **Satisfactory** | Readable overall, but uneven formatting and/or frequent unclear wording distracts or slows the reader. |
| **Fair** | Hard to read: messy presentation and/or language that often leaves the reader confused about what is meant. |

### Timeline & team roles – 5%

How you organise the remaining work through milestones and named responsibilities. Plans may change later; this is judged as a reasonable starting point.

| | |
|---|---|
| **Excellent** | Dated or week-based milestones cover the remaining work; responsibilities are assigned to named members; the schedule looks realistic for five people. |
| **Good** | The plan and roles are mostly clear; a few milestones or assignments are vague. |
| **Satisfactory** | A basic plan or role list exists, but the timeline or ownership is incomplete. |
| **Fair** | Little usable planning; roles are missing, unclear, or unrealistic. |